

וזאת הברכה

V'Zot HaBerachah

Deuteronomy 33:1–34:12 — Moses blesses the tribes, and dies

Mega Bible

parasha sheet

theothermatthewmiller.com



THE PARASHA BY THE NUMBERS

41

VERSES

515

WORDS

266

DISTINCT ROOTS

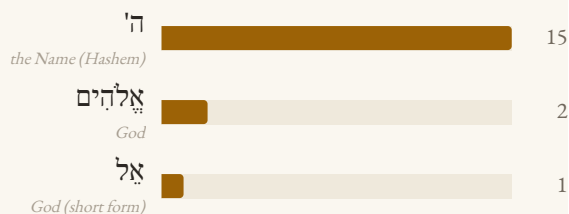
13

HAPAX LEGOMENA

MOST FREQUENT ROOTS



WHAT THE PARASHA CALLS GOD



Unlike Ha'azinu's six divine names, V'Zot HaBerachah mostly just says 'ה' — plainly, fifteen times, as Moses blesses each tribe, and one last time as He buries Moses "by the mouth of the Name" (34:5).

Averaging 12.6 words a verse. The longest verse is 34:1 at 22 words — Moses climbing Mount Nebo to view the land he will not enter; the shortest, 33:25, has only 5 — his eye undimmed, his vigor unabated, at 120.

THIRTEEN WORDS THAT OCCUR NOWHERE ELSE IN THE BIBLE

33:2	אֲשֶׁרֶת	a fire-law (obscure hapax; trad. "fiery law")	33:3	חָבַב	he cherishes, holds dear
33:3	תָּבוּ	they are gathered, encamp	33:3	מִדְּבַרְתֶּיהָ	of your words / at your feet
33:10	קְטֹרֶת	incense	33:12	חָפָה	he covers, shelters
33:14	גָּרַשׁ	yield, produce	33:19	שֹׁפַע	abundance, hidden stores
33:19	וּשְׁפוּנֵי	and the hidden treasures of	33:22	זָנַק	he leaps forth
33:25	מִנְעָלֶיהָ	your bolt, bar	33:25	דְּבָאָה	your rest, quiet
34:7	לִחָה	freshness, vigor			

Hapax legomena, counted against the whole Tanakh: thirteen of this parasha's 266 roots are used exactly once in all of Scripture, and 184 more appear only once here. Half of them cluster in Moses' blessing of Levi and Naphtali (33:3, 33:19, 33:25) — the poem gets hardest to translate

exactly where it is most affectionate.

תּוֹרָה צְוֵה־לָנוּ מִשָּׁה / מוֹרָשָׁה 33:4

מִוִּרְשָׁה “a holding, an inheritance” becomes the everyday word for cultural and national heritage

is מורשה/מורשה/Moses charged us with the Torah, a possession for the congregation of Jacob. Biblical simply a holding — a plot of land one owns or inherits (Ezekiel 11:15, on who owns Israel's territory) — or, here, the Torah itself as Israel's inheritance. Modern Hebrew narrows the word to abstract cultural inheritance: מורשת ("heritage") names historic sites (אתרי מורשת), the legacy a society hands down (מורשת קרב), in the IDF), and gives its name to government bodies such as the Ministry for Jerusalem and Heritage. The plain sense "an inherited holding" survives mainly in this verse and in legal/historical Hebrew; for most speakers מורשה/מורשה now means legacy, not real estate.

אַשְׁרִיךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל 33:29

the Torah's closing exclamation of praise becomes a stock congratulatory phrase, quoted verbatim on Hebrew street posters

— the next-to-last verse of the Torah, Moses' final exclamation over the nation he is about to leave. אֲשֶׁרִיךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל מִי כְמוֹךָ עם נִשְׁעָה בַּהּ אֲשֶׁרִיכֶם specifically became a fixed congratulatory tag: quoted, often in the plural אֲשֶׁרִיכֶם, as the headline of celebratory pashkevilim (Hebrew street posters) and flyers announcing a simcha or communal achievement — two items in the National Library of Israel's ephemera collection reuse the exact biblical wording as their title. In ordinary speech אֲשֶׁרִיךְ/אֲשֶׁרִיךְ still simply "lucky/fortunate you," now usually addressed to an individual rather than to the nation.



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FL5334146



Menachem Friedman archive, National Library of Israel
FL263351034

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אשריך ישראל מי כמוך.

A Hebrew street poster (pashkevil) headlined with the verse almost verbatim, through its own next words "מי כמוך".

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אשריכם ישראל.

Ephemera (Menachem Friedman archive) using the plural אֲשֶׁרִיכֶם for the verse's אֲשֶׁרִיךְ — a stock congratulatory address.

סִמְךָ מִשָּׁה אֶת־יָדָיו עָלָיו / סְמִיכָה 34:9

Moses' hand-laying on Joshua becomes סְמִיכָה, the institution of rabbinic ordination

— Moses transfers his authority to Joshua by the physical act of סְמִיכָה, laying his hands on him (cf. Numbers 27:18, 23). Rabbinic tradition reads this literal gesture as the origin of סְמִיכָה, the unbroken chain of ordination by which a teacher confers rabbinic authority on a student; the word survives in modern Hebrew as the standard term for rabbinic (and by extension academic) ordination, with a תעודת סְמִיכָה ("ordination certificate/diploma") as its concrete artifact — exactly the kind of document the NLI's street-poster collection preserves. The same root ס-מ-כ also gives modern Hebrew על לסמוך ("to rely/depend on") and סמכות ("authority"), both descendants of the same image of one thing physically resting its weight on another.

ATTESTED · NATIONAL LIBRARY OF ISRAEL · 1998

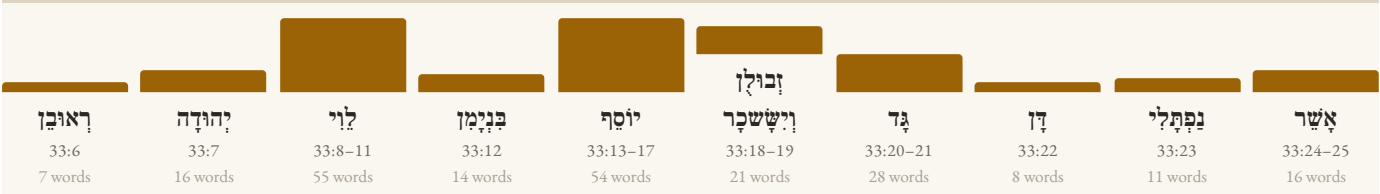
תעודת סמכי.

A Hebrew street poster (pashkevil) titled "Ordination Certificate" — the modern noun made into a concrete public-notice document.



National Library of Israel collection, 1998
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THE TRIBES MOSES BLESSED



Ten blessings for eleven tribes (Joseph standing for both Ephraim and Manasseh) — and one tribe, **Simeon**, gets no blessing at all. Ibn Ezra (on 33:6) notes the gap and explains it by Simeon's own history: their territory was absorbed inside Judah's allotment (Joshua 19:1, 9), so their share is folded into Judah's blessing rather than named on its own — the one tribe Jacob himself had also rebuked (Genesis 49:5–7) goes unmentioned twice.

MY NOTES

Nothing recorded yet — the notes field is empty for every verse of Deuteronomy 33–34.